

Active Transportation & the Built Environment

Accessibility, Design, and Planning

Fall 2026

Maryam Hosseini

City & Regional Planning

Where are We Going?

W1: "How do you define walkability?"

W2 S2: Walkable for whom? Where?
Trip purpose and competing impacts

W3: Space and place
How streets are experienced

W4 S1: Space and place
comfort, safety, and staying

Background Concept

Conceptualization

Formulating **a systematized concept** through reasoning about the **background concept**, in light of the goals of research.

Collier, D. (2026) Measurement Validity.

Where are We Going?

W1: "How do you define walkability?"

W2 S2: Walkable for whom? Where?
Trip purpose and competing impacts

W3: Space and place
How streets are experienced

W4 S1: Space and place
comfort, safety, and staying

W4 S2: Walk/rollability as a systematized concept

W5 S1: Urban accessibility as a systematized concept

Background Concept

Conceptualization

Formulating **a systematized concept** through reasoning about the **background concept**, in light of the goals of research.

Systematized Concepts *Definition!*

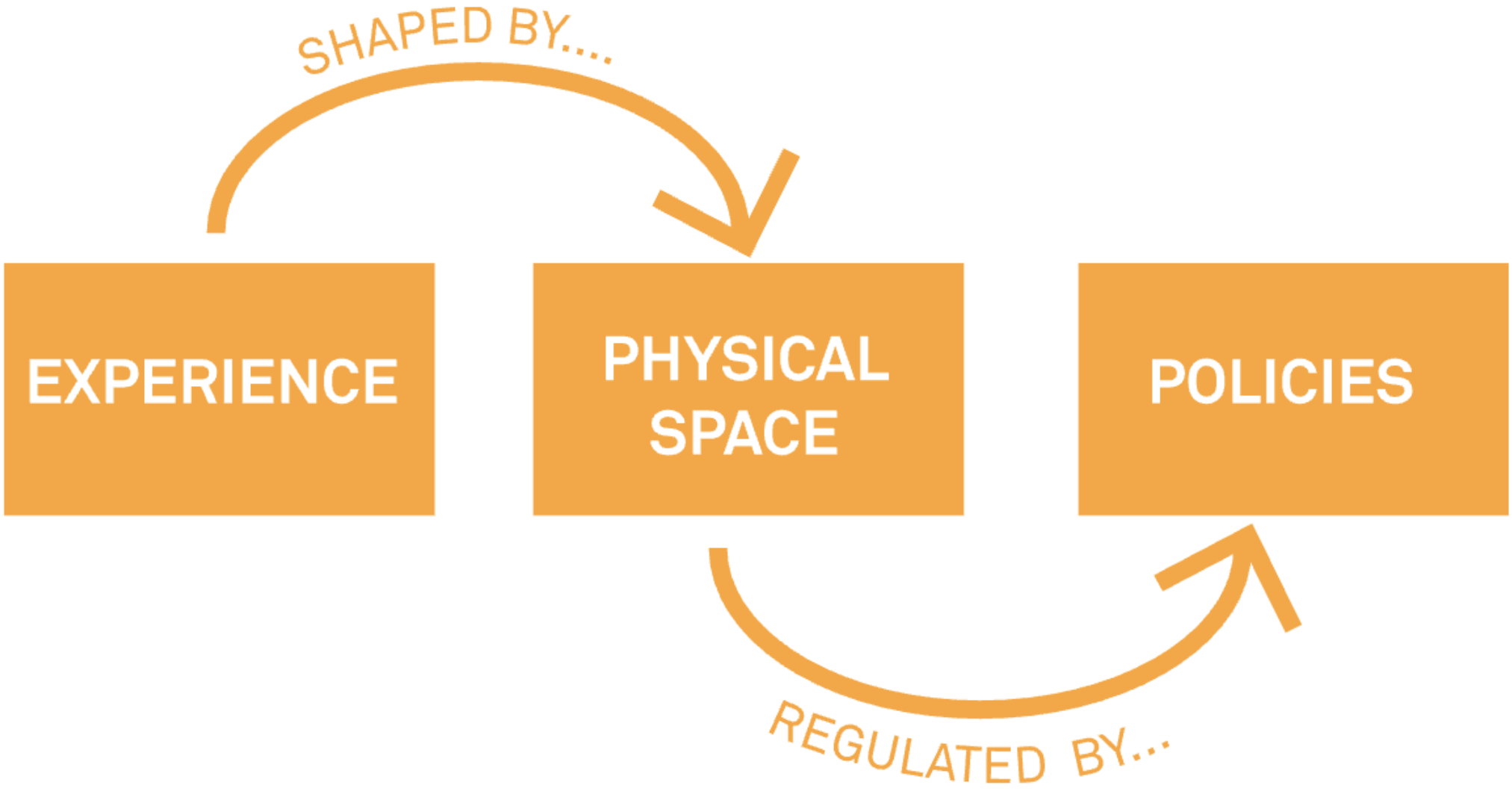
A specific formulation of a concept used by a given scholar or group of scholars; commonly involves an explicit definition.

Collier, D. (2026) Measurement Validity.

"Nothing is experienced by itself,
but always in relation to its surroundings,
the sequences of events leading up to it,
the memory of past experiences."

Kevin Lynch, The Image of the City, P.2

Is something missing?



Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Lynch

To identify qualities of physical environment that most strongly shape peoples' images of their city.

The Image of the City "considers the visual quality of the American city by studying the **mental image of that city which is held by its citizens**."

"What we seek is not a final but an open-ended order, capable of continuous further development!"

Kevin Lynch, The Image of the City

How did Lynch define "legibility" or "imageability"?

3 parts of city image

1. Identity: An element in the environment can be distinguished from other elements.

2. Structure: The spatial pattern of the element in relation to other elements.

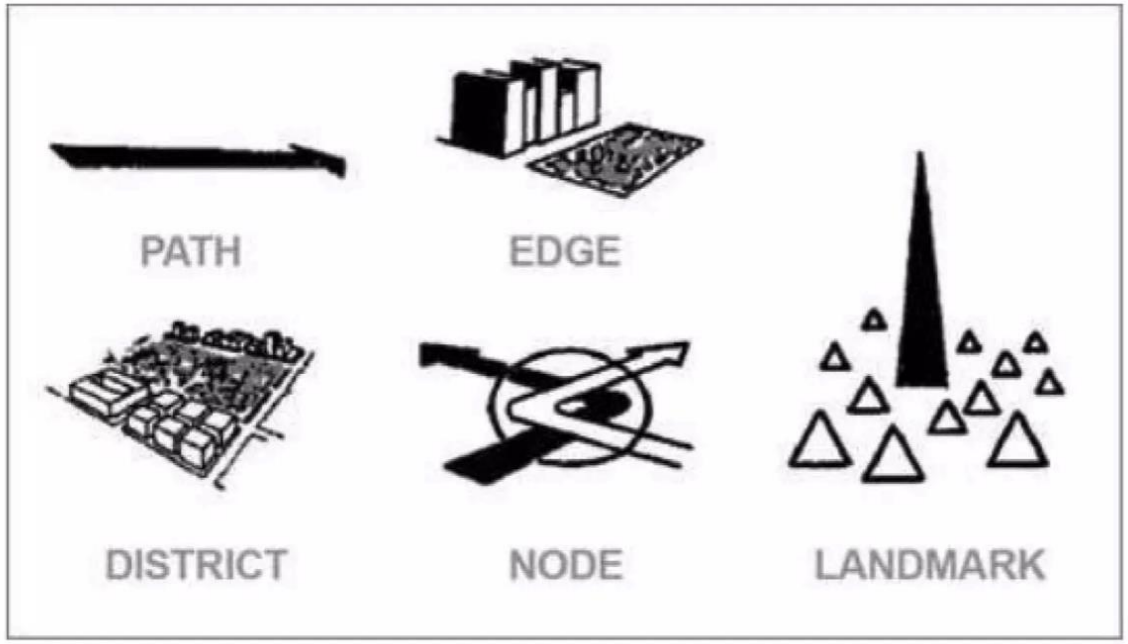
3. Meaning: The personal significance of the element.

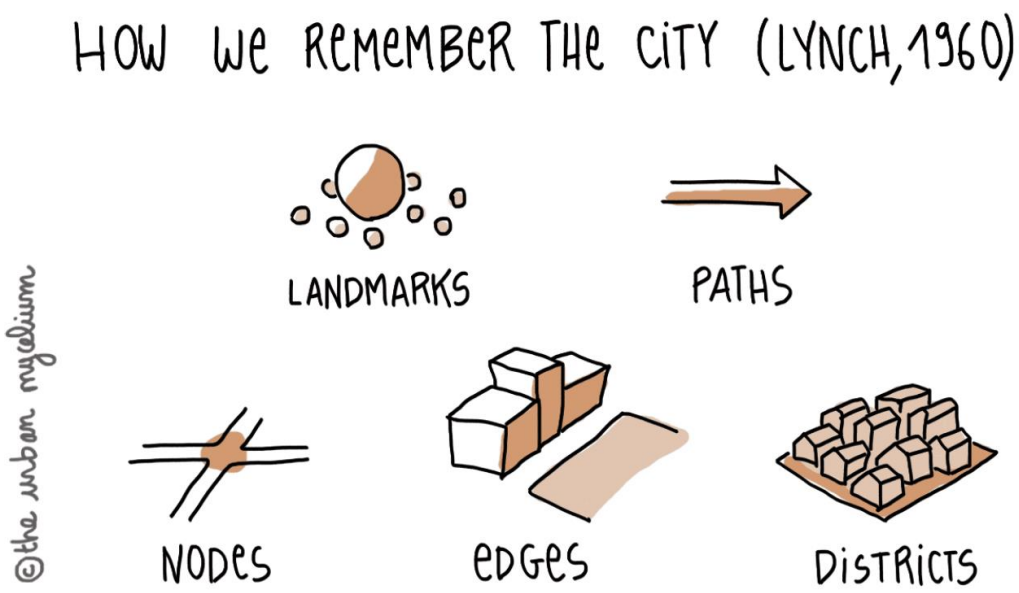
Imageability: the ease with which the parts of a city can be recognized by its users.

Elements of the City Image

- **Path:** Channels along which people move, (streets, walkways)
- **Landmark:** A physical reference point that is viewed from the outside. (buildings, mountain)
- **Edge:** A linear boundary or break between two areas, such as a shoreline, wall, railroad, or edge of development.
- **Node:** A strategic point that people can enter and that serves as a focus of movement or activity, (intersection, transit stop)
- **District:** A medium to large area of the city with a recognizable character that people can mentally enter and identify as a distinct part of the city.

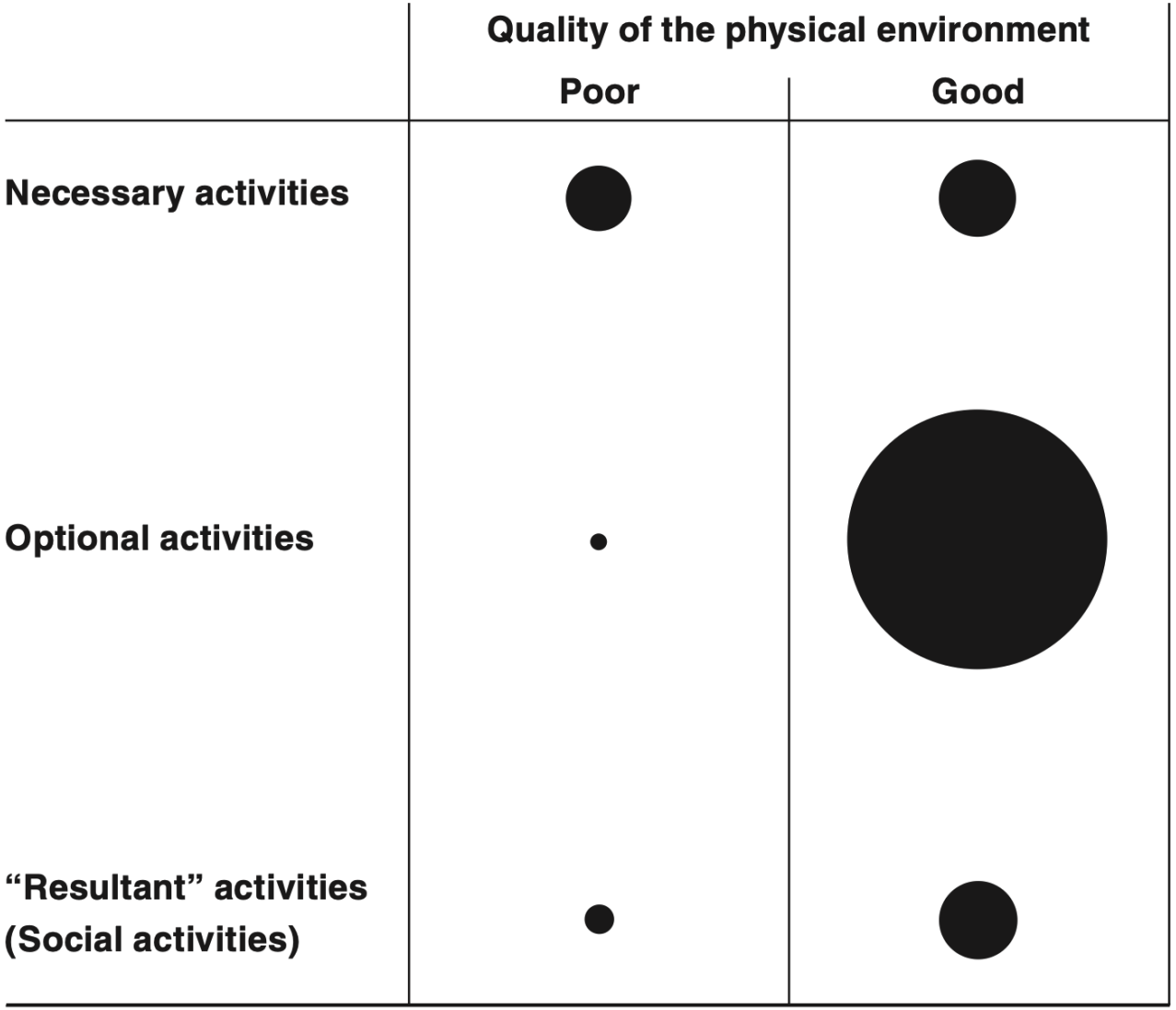
Elements of the City Image





Jan Gehl: Activity Types

- Necessary / functional
- Optional / recreational
- Social



Lynch, 1960, The Image of the City



60 km/h architecture

Large spaces, huge signage,

no details, no people

Birgitte Svarre, 2015, UW



Human scale, many details, interaction

Birgitte Svarre, 2015, UW



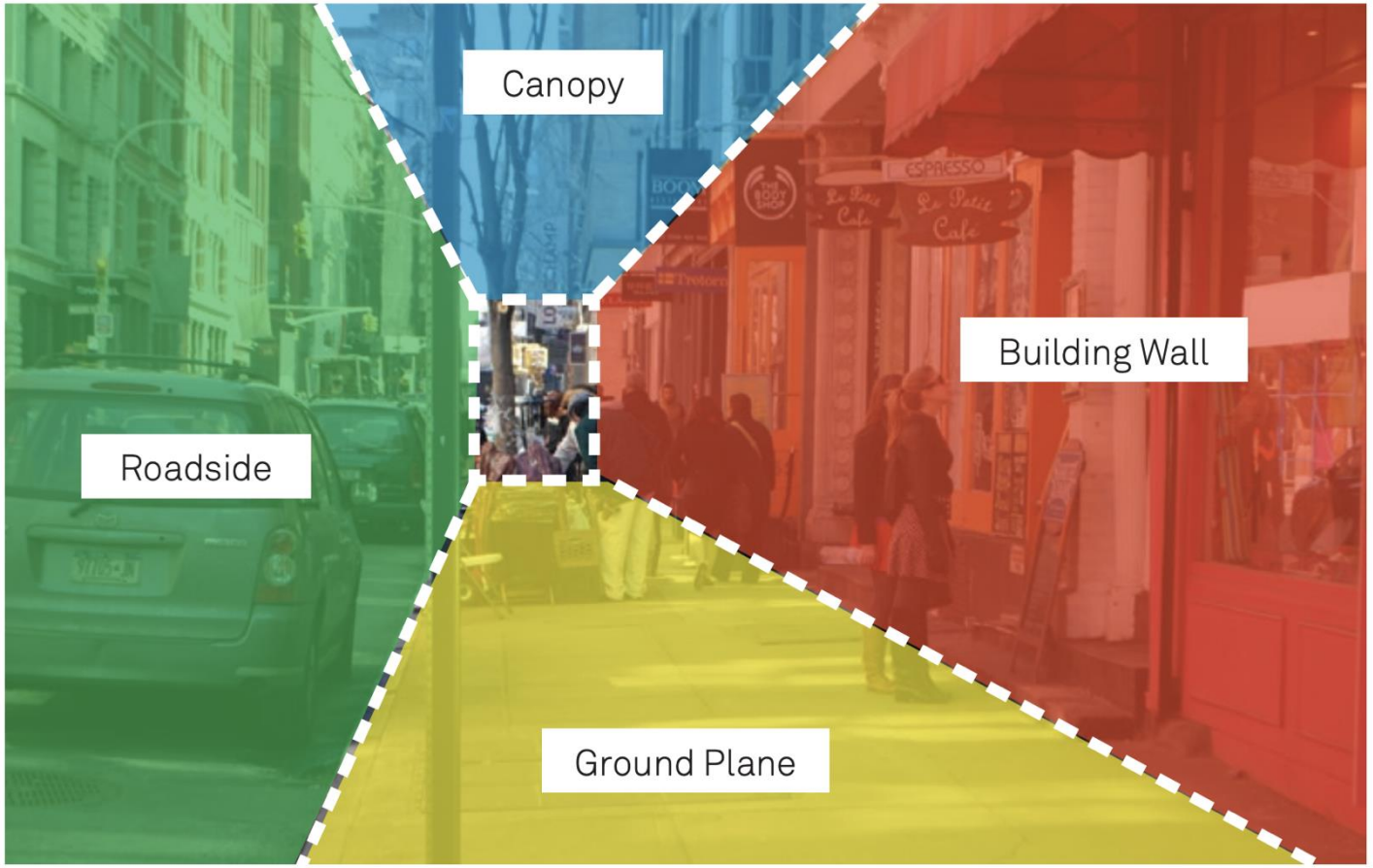
Text: Birgitte Svarre, 2015, UW

"The ballet of the good city sidewalk never repeats itself from place to place, and in any one place is always replete with new improvisations."

Jane Jacobs, Death and Life of Great American Cities, P.50

The Sidewalk Room

Judging from the pedestrian perspective, the sidewalk is conceptualized as a room with four planes.

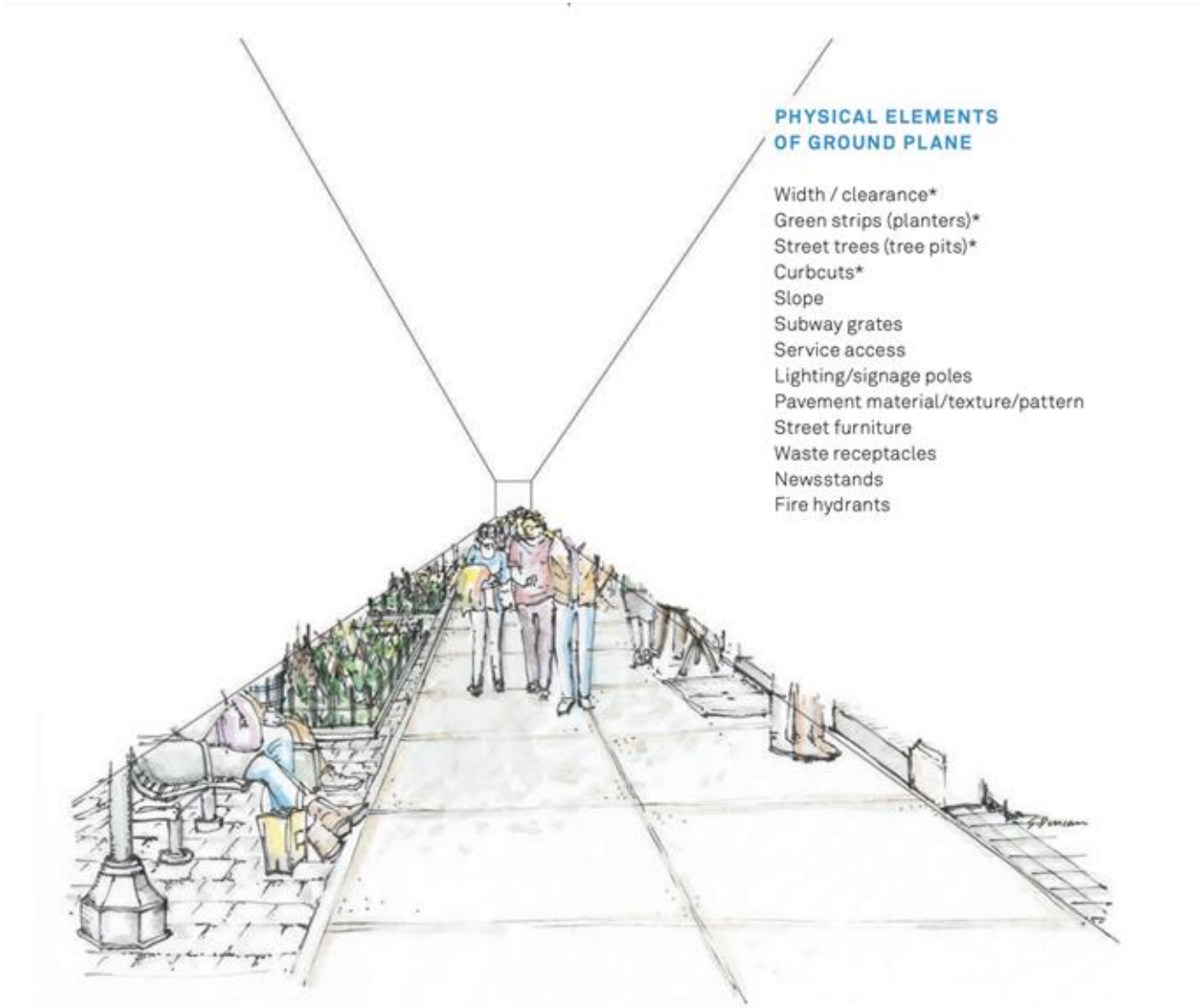


Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Ground Plane

Four Different Zones :

1. Frontage Zone
2. Pedestrian Through Zone
3. Furnishing Zone
4. Buffer / Curb Zone

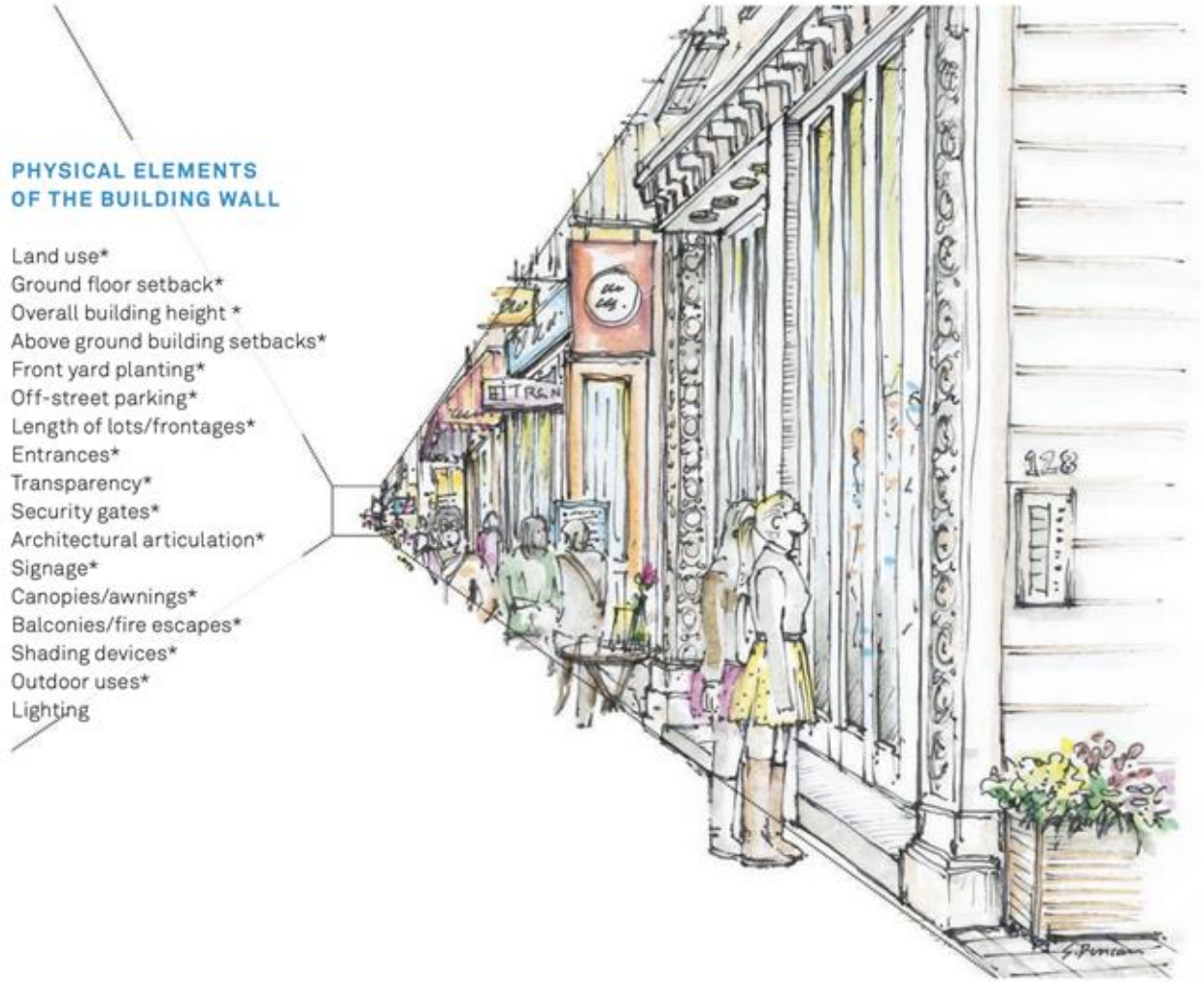


*elements affected by zoning

Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Building Wall

Zoning regulations typically have the greatest impact on this plane. The position of the building wall plane (set back or on the property line), can greatly affect the sidewalk experience.

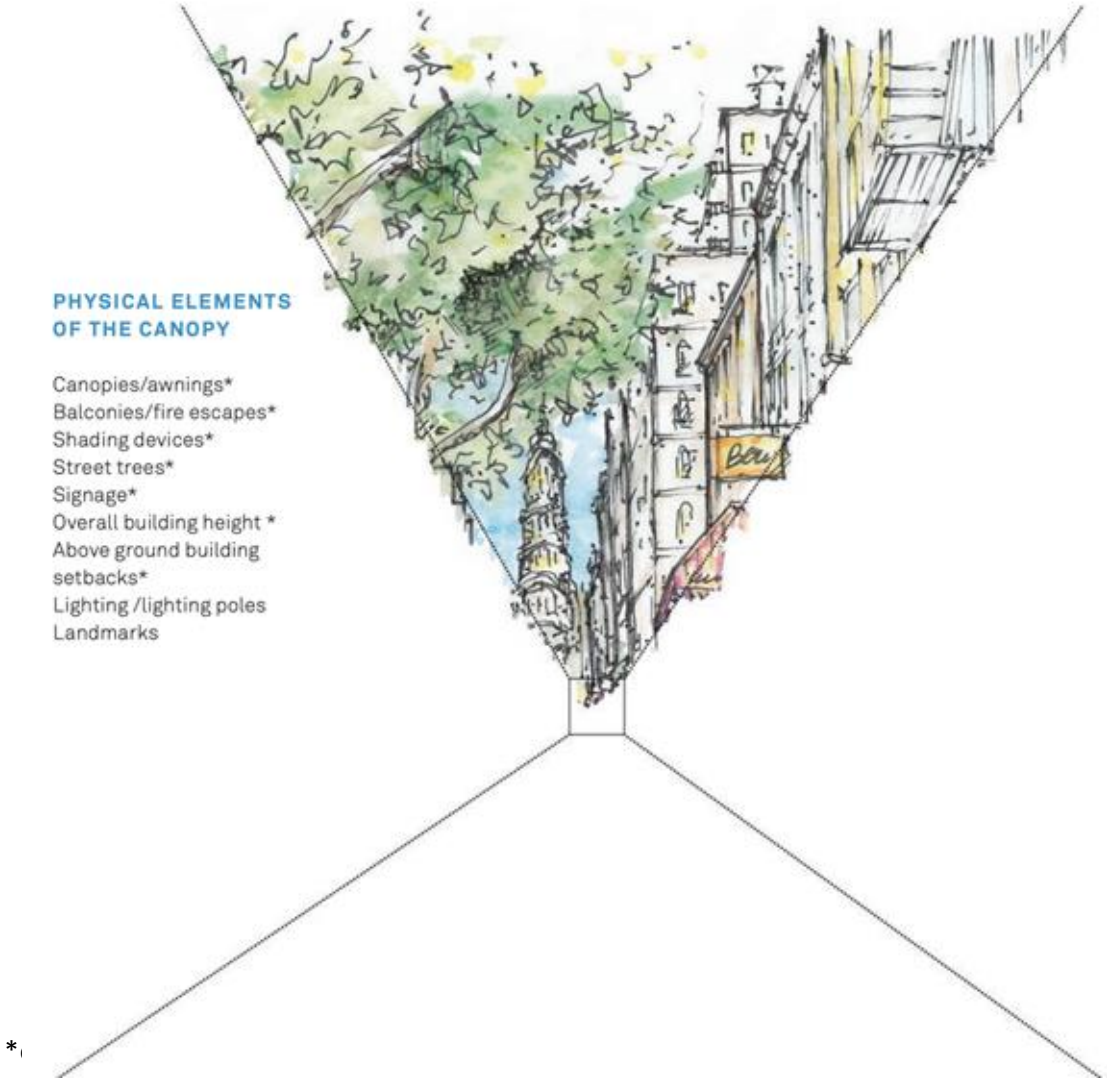


*elements affected by zoning

Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Canopy

The amount of sky apparent to pedestrians.
Sidewalks lined with trees provide a strong and diverse canopy filled with tree branches or heavy foliage and change seasonally.



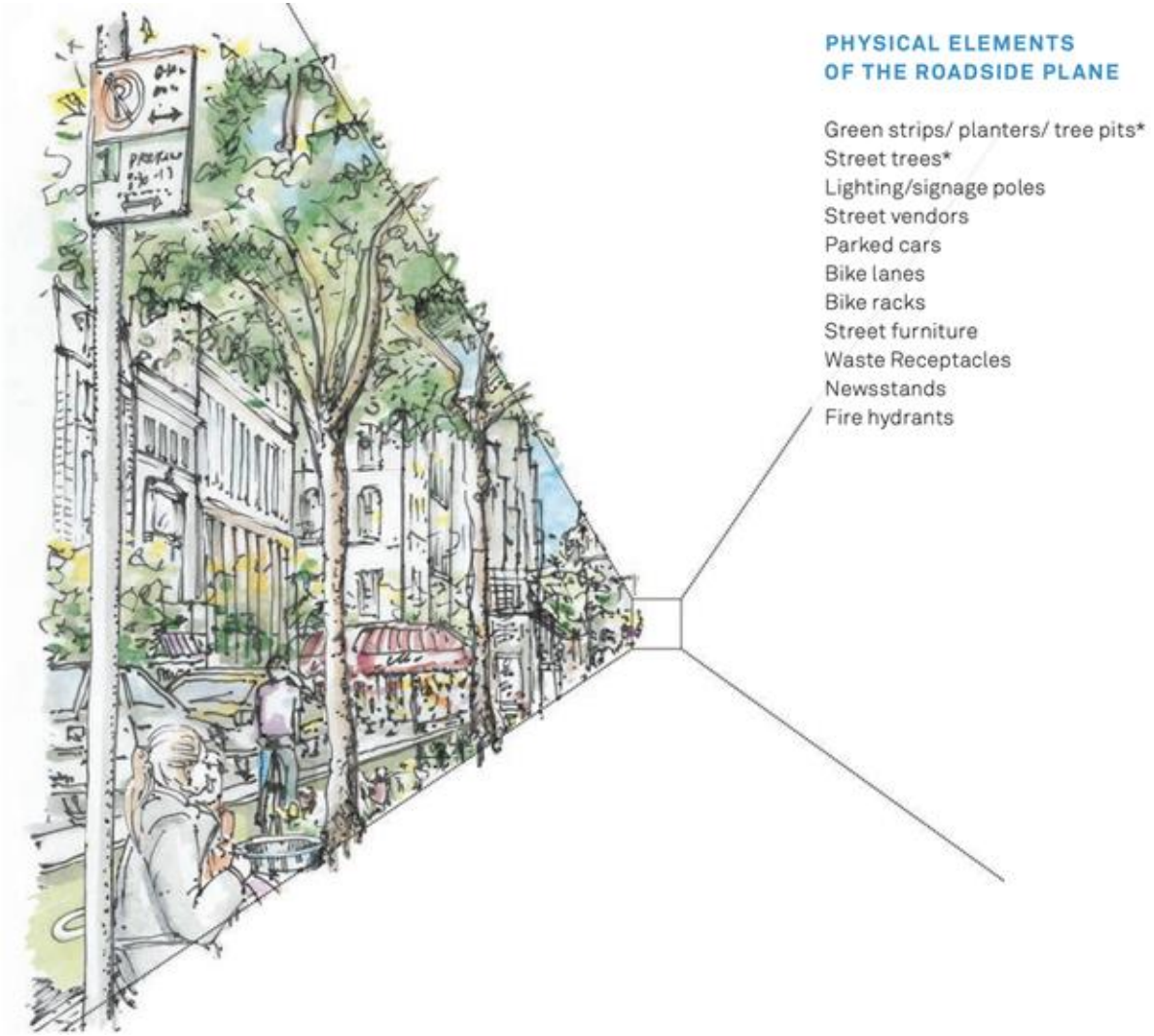
Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Roadside

Defined primarily by the rhythm of vertical physical elements like tree trunks and light poles that line the immediate edge of the sidewalk.

Safety from accident

Depth of view

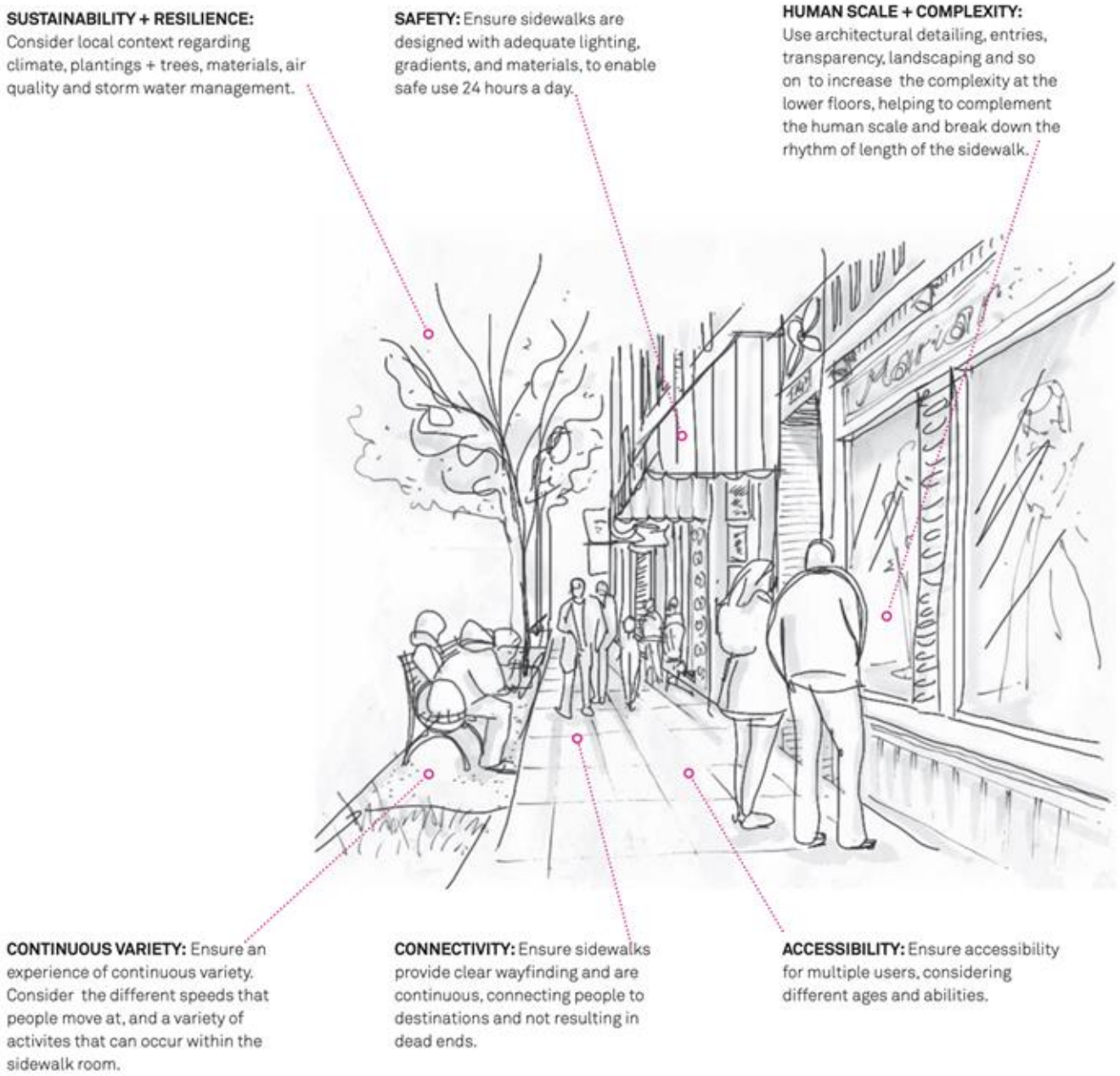


*elements affected by zoning

Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Sidewalks

Factors Contributing to Active Design Experience



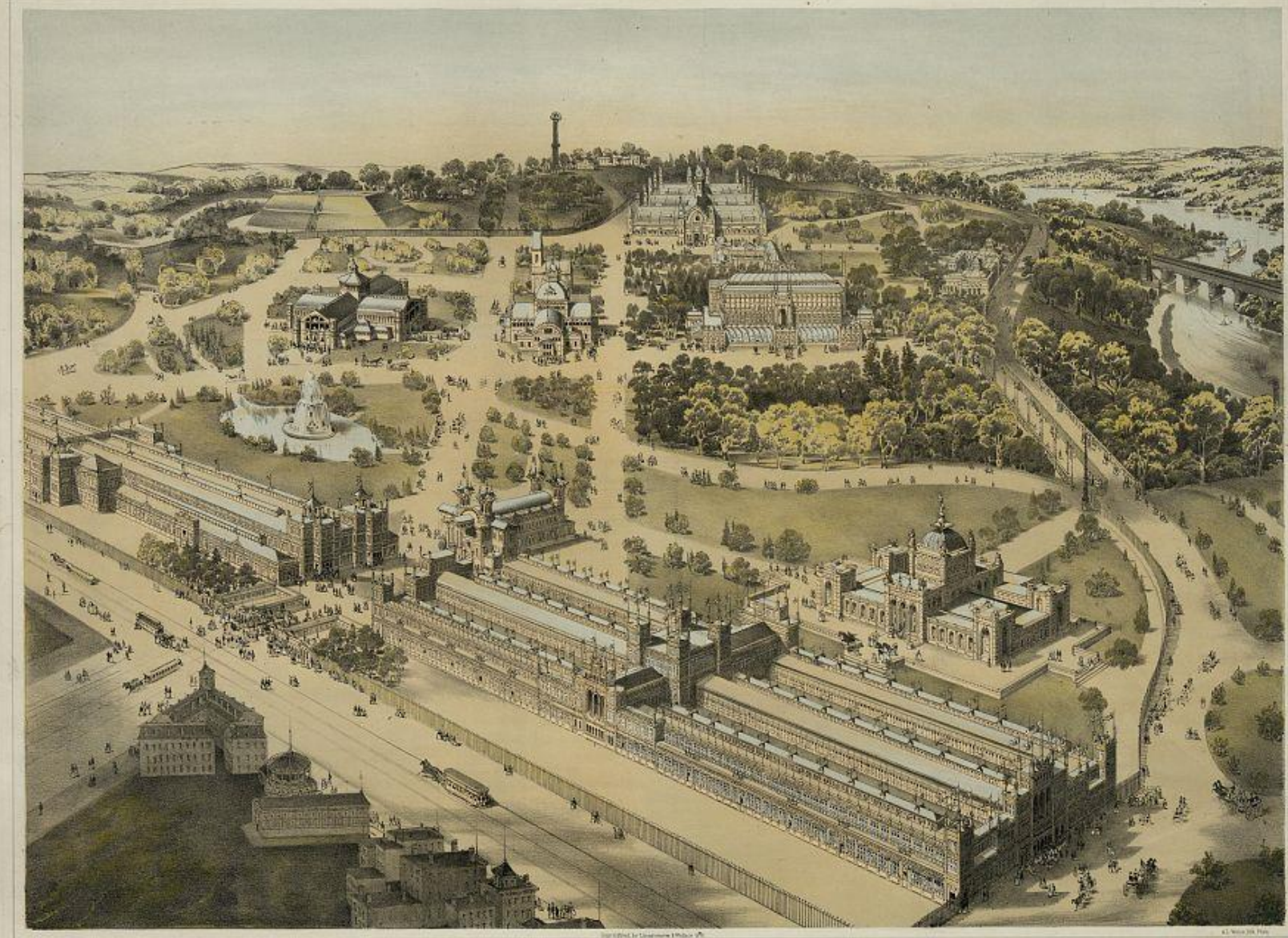
Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience

Sidewalk Regulations (NYC)

Factors Contributing to Active Design Experience



Alexandros Washburn, 2013, NYC Active Design: The sidewalk experience



·VIEW·OF·THE·GROUND·AND·BUILDINGS·OF·INTERNATIONAL·EXHIBITION.

FAIRMOUNT PARK 1876. PHILADELPHIA.

MICROFILMED

Draw from Memory

Without using your phone or looking at a map:

- **Draw a map of Berkeley as you picture it in your mind.**
- Draw enough that someone looking at your map could understand **how you think the city is organized**.
- Include whatever places, routes, boundaries, areas, or features come naturally to mind.
- Add names or annotations if useful.
- Do not worry about geographic accuracy.
- There is no need to fill the entire page or represent all of Berkeley.
- **Do not compare maps yet.**

Read your Map through Lynch

Now look back at your map and identify:

- **Paths:** routes you move along
- **Edges:** boundaries or breaks
- **Districts:** recognizable areas
- **Nodes:** important points of activity or decision
- **Landmarks:** recognizable reference points

Mark each type directly on your drawing. Then ask yourself:

Which types appear most strongly in my mental image? Which are missing?

Share Maps

In groups of **3 - 4**, compare your maps.
Discuss:

1. What appears on many maps?
2. What appears on only one map?
3. What did was exaggerated, simplified, or omitted?
4. Where do your mental boundaries of Berkeley differ?
5. What might explain these differences?

Choose **one similarity and one striking difference** to share with the class.

Our Maps of Berkeley

What does our collection of maps tell us about Berkeley?

Are we mapping Berkeley, or are we mapping our experience of Berkeley?

take a picture and add your map to this Miro board!



Final Project

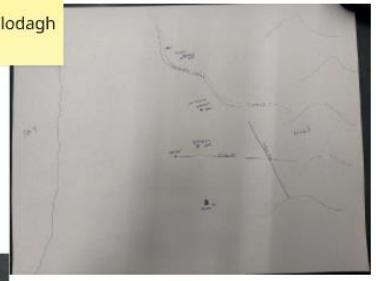
Let's work together!
Scan this to access our Miro Board!



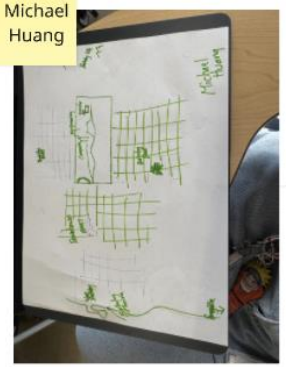
The image of Berkeley

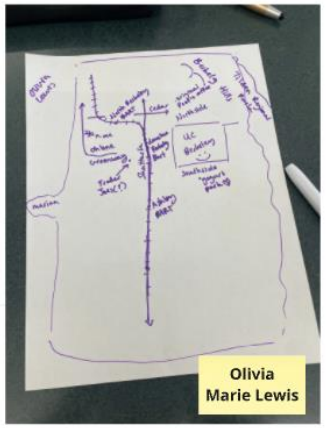
W3 S2 - Sp 9 2026

Clodagh

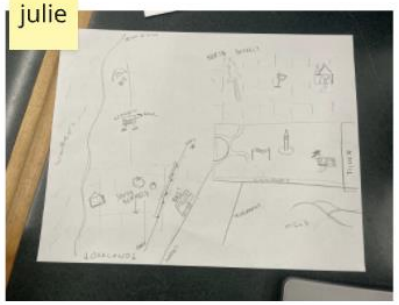


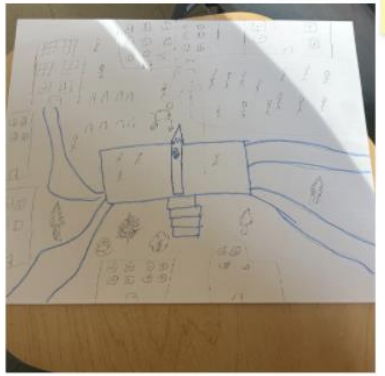
Michael Huang





julie

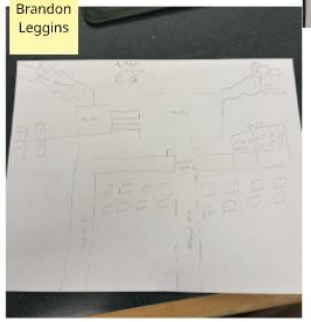


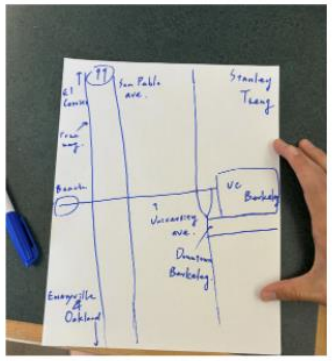


Adriana

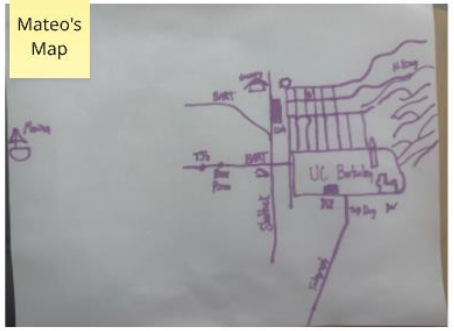


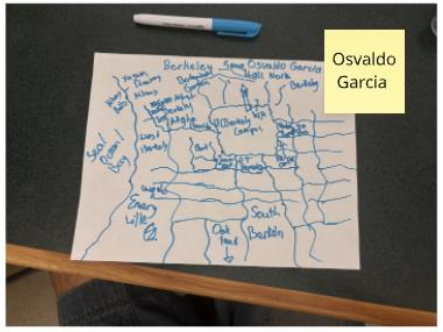
Brandon Leggins



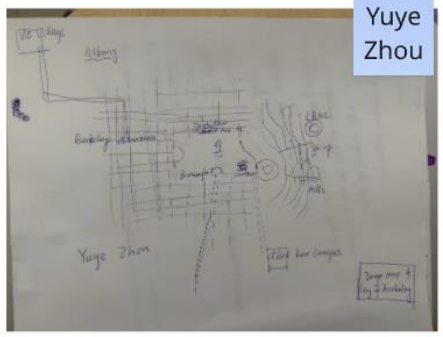


Mateo's Map

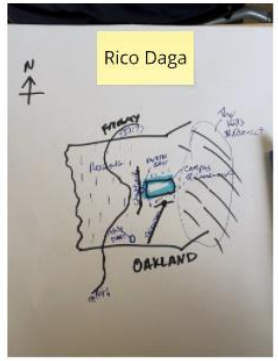




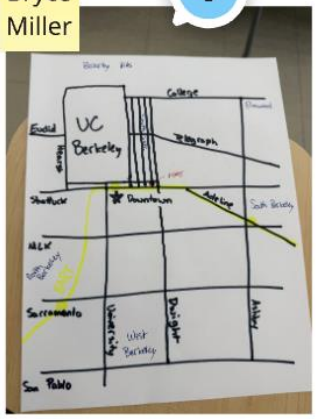
Yuye Zhou

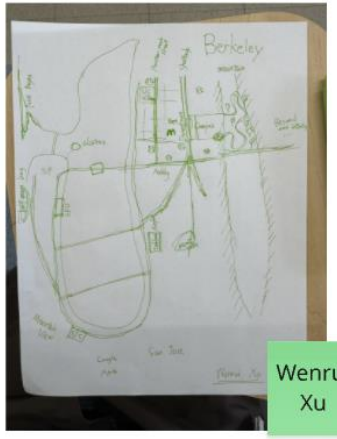


Rico Daga



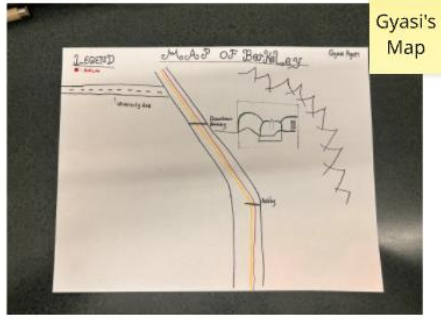
Bryce Miller





Wenrui Xu

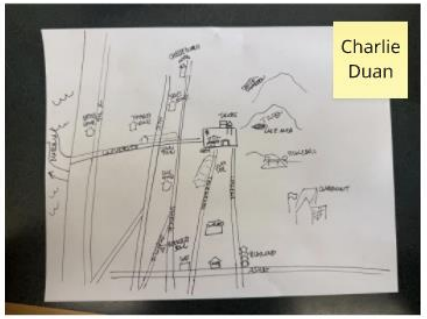
Gyasi's Map





Anwar

Charlie Duan



Aqdas

